

Supply Chain and Logistics English Jargon Quick Reference

Field-specific terms, contrast pairs, and high-pressure sentence frames

Audience: supply-chain managers, planners, buyers, logistics coordinators, warehouse leaders, procurement teams, customs staff, and operations managers

Focus: A supply-chain English curriculum for forecasting, shortages, purchasing, inventory, warehouse operations, logistics delays, supplier performance, customs, risk, and crisis communication.

Designed for advanced ESL learners who already use professional English and need industry-specific terminology, realistic meetings, role-play pressure, careful pushback, and polished workplace outputs.

Teaching stance: this is language and workplace-communication training, not legal, medical, financial, safety, or regulatory advice. Instructors should connect every scenario to the learner's current company policies, local rules, and approved procedures.

Nomenclature and Jargon

These are classroom working definitions. Learners should adapt wording to their organization's policies, systems, and local regulatory environment.

Demand Planning and Forecast Bias

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
forecast	Forward-looking estimate based on assumptions, trends, constraints, and known risks.	clarify forecast; document forecast	Contrast: forecast should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify forecast and the evidence that supports it.
forecast bias	In supply chain and logistics, forecast bias is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to discuss forecast changes without treating estimates as promises.	clarify forecast bias; document forecast bias	Contrast: forecast bias should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify forecast bias and the evidence that supports it.
demand signal	In supply chain and logistics, demand signal is a defined information asset or analytical construct used to measure, explain, or predict an outcome. Use it when teams need to discuss forecast changes without treating estimates as promises.	clarify demand signal; document demand signal	Contrast: demand signal should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify demand signal and the evidence that supports it.
S&OP	In supply chain and logistics, S&OP is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to discuss forecast changes without treating estimates as promises.	clarify S&OP; document S&OP	Contrast: S&OP should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify S&OP and the evidence that supports it.

Procurement and Supplier Performance

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
purchase order	In supply chain and logistics, purchase order is a formal intake or routing mechanism that starts work, seeks a decision, or transfers responsibility. Use it when teams need to challenge supplier promises using evidence and contract language.	clarify purchase order; document purchase order	Contrast: purchase order should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify purchase order and the evidence that supports it.
lead time	In supply chain and logistics, lead time is an operational constraint that affects how much work can be completed, by whom, and by when. Use it when teams need to challenge supplier promises using evidence and contract language.	clarify lead time; document lead time	Contrast: lead time should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify lead time and the evidence that supports it.
OTIF	In supply chain and logistics, OTIF is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to challenge supplier promises using evidence and contract language.	clarify OTIF; document OTIF	Contrast: OTIF should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify OTIF and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
allocation	In supply chain and logistics, allocation is an operational constraint that affects how much work can be completed, by whom, and by when. Use it when teams need to challenge supplier promises using evidence and contract language.	clarify allocation; document allocation	Contrast: allocation should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify allocation and the evidence that supports it.

Inventory, Safety Stock, and Service Levels

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
safety stock	In supply chain and logistics, safety stock is a performance or governance dimension that must be protected through defined evidence, thresholds, and accountability. Use it when teams need to explain inventory tradeoffs between service and cash.	clarify safety stock; document safety stock	Contrast: safety stock should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify safety stock and the evidence that supports it.
stockout	In supply chain and logistics, stockout is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to explain inventory tradeoffs between service and cash.	clarify stockout; document stockout	Contrast: stockout should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify stockout and the evidence that supports it.
service level	In supply chain and logistics, service level is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to explain inventory tradeoffs between service and cash.	clarify service level; document service level	Contrast: service level should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify service level and the evidence that supports it.
SKU	In supply chain and logistics, SKU is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to explain inventory tradeoffs between service and cash.	clarify SKU; document SKU	Contrast: SKU should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify SKU and the evidence that supports it.

Warehousing and Fulfillment

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
pick rate	In supply chain and logistics, pick rate is a measurable indicator used to quantify performance, exposure, capacity, quality, or change over time. Use it when teams need to report warehouse constraints and fulfillment risk.	track pick rate; explain a change in pick rate	Contrast: pick rate measures a result or condition; it does not, by itself, prove the cause. Example: Before we act, let us track pick rate by segment and explain what changed.
slotting	In supply chain and logistics, slotting is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to report warehouse constraints and fulfillment risk.	clarify slotting; document slotting	Contrast: slotting should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify slotting and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
cycle count	In supply chain and logistics, cycle count is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to report warehouse constraints and fulfillment risk.	clarify cycle count; document cycle count	Contrast: cycle count should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify cycle count and the evidence that supports it.
backlog	Ordered body of work waiting to be refined, prioritized, assigned, or completed.	clarify backlog; document backlog	Contrast: backlog should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify backlog and the evidence that supports it.

Freight, Routing, and Carrier Delays

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
incoterms	In supply chain and logistics, incoterms is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to communicate transportation risk precisely.	clarify incoterms; document incoterms	Contrast: incoterms should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify incoterms and the evidence that supports it.
carrier	In supply chain and logistics, carrier is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to communicate transportation risk precisely.	clarify carrier; document carrier	Contrast: carrier should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify carrier and the evidence that supports it.
expedite	In supply chain and logistics, expedite is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to communicate transportation risk precisely.	clarify expedite; document expedite	Contrast: expedite should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify expedite and the evidence that supports it.
ETA	In supply chain and logistics, ETA is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to communicate transportation risk precisely.	clarify ETA; document ETA	Contrast: ETA should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify ETA and the evidence that supports it.

Customs, Trade Compliance, and Documentation

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
HS code	In supply chain and logistics, HS code is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to prevent shipment delays caused by incomplete documents.	clarify HS code; document HS code	Contrast: HS code should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify HS code and the evidence that supports it.
country of origin	In supply chain and logistics, country of origin is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to prevent shipment delays caused by incomplete documents.	clarify country of origin; document country of origin	Contrast: country of origin should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify country of origin and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
commercial invoice	In supply chain and logistics, commercial invoice is a communication or market-facing element that must match evidence, audience, channel, and approval boundaries. Use it when teams need to prevent shipment delays caused by incomplete documents.	clarify commercial invoice; document commercial invoice	Contrast: commercial invoice should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify commercial invoice and the evidence that supports it.
broker	In supply chain and logistics, broker is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to prevent shipment delays caused by incomplete documents.	clarify broker; document broker	Contrast: broker should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify broker and the evidence that supports it.

Supply Risk and Business Continuity

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
business continuity	In supply chain and logistics, business continuity is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to discuss disruptions with contingency and prioritization language.	clarify business continuity; document business continuity	Contrast: business continuity should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify business continuity and the evidence that supports it.
dual sourcing	In supply chain and logistics, dual sourcing is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to discuss disruptions with contingency and prioritization language.	clarify dual sourcing; document dual sourcing	Contrast: dual sourcing should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify dual sourcing and the evidence that supports it.
allocation	In supply chain and logistics, allocation is an operational constraint that affects how much work can be completed, by whom, and by when. Use it when teams need to discuss disruptions with contingency and prioritization language.	clarify allocation; document allocation	Contrast: allocation should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify allocation and the evidence that supports it.
constraint	In supply chain and logistics, constraint is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to discuss disruptions with contingency and prioritization language.	clarify constraint; document constraint	Contrast: constraint should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify constraint and the evidence that supports it.

Executive S&OP Decisions

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
S&OP	In supply chain and logistics, S&OP is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to turn cross-functional disagreement into decisions and assumptions.	clarify S&OP; document S&OP	Contrast: S&OP should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify S&OP and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
consensus plan	In supply chain and logistics, consensus plan is a structured course of action that assigns priorities, sequencing, assumptions, and responsible roles. Use it when teams need to turn cross-functional disagreement into decisions and assumptions.	align on the consensus plan; revise the consensus plan	Contrast: consensus plan sets an intended course of action; it is not proof that the work is feasible or approved. Example: Before we revise the consensus plan, we need to test the dependency and resource assumptions.
scenario	In supply chain and logistics, scenario is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to turn cross-functional disagreement into decisions and assumptions.	clarify scenario; document scenario	Contrast: scenario should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify scenario and the evidence that supports it.
owner	Named person or role accountable for a decision, action, deliverable, or risk.	clarify owner; document owner	Contrast: owner should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify owner and the evidence that supports it.

Industry-Specific Meeting Moves

Situation	Useful language
Demand Planning and Forecast Bias	Before we commit, I want to confirm forecast, forecast bias, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If forecast bias, lead time, capacity, and inventory exposure need review., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Procurement and Supplier Performance	Before we commit, I want to confirm purchase order, lead time, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If capacity, allocation, purchase order terms, and recovery evidence are unclear., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Inventory, Safety Stock, and Service Levels	Before we commit, I want to confirm safety stock, stockout, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If demand variability, lead time, margin, service level, and stockout risk differ by item., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Warehousing and Fulfillment	Before we commit, I want to confirm pick rate, slotting, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If slotting, labor, scanner data, training, and error types need diagnosis., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Freight, Routing, and Carrier Delays	Before we commit, I want to confirm incoterms, carrier, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If mode, route, cutoff time, expedite cost, and customer promise need a decision., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Customs, Trade Compliance, and Documentation	Before we commit, I want to confirm HS code, country of origin, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If classification, country of origin, valuation, and document consistency matter., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Supply Risk and Business Continuity	Before we commit, I want to confirm business continuity, dual sourcing, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If allocation, alternate sources, inventory position, and customer priority need governance., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Executive S&OP Decisions	Before we commit, I want to confirm S&OP, consensus plan, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If the executive team must agree on assumptions, risk, upside, and owners., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.

High-pressure pushback frames

- I understand the urgency. The risk is that we move faster than the evidence or process supports.

- I am not blocking the goal. I am naming the condition we need before the decision is safe and credible.
- If we accept this risk, we should name the owner, document the assumption, and define the trigger for escalation.
- That may be possible, but not under the current scope, timeline, or approval path.
- Let's separate what we know, what we assume, and what still needs confirmation.

Contrast Pairs

Do not confuse	Useful distinction
forecast vs S&OP	In demand planning and forecast bias, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
purchase order vs allocation	In procurement and supplier performance, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
safety stock vs SKU	In inventory, safety stock, and service levels, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
pick rate vs backlog	In warehousing and fulfillment, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
incoterms vs ETA	In freight, routing, and carrier delays, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
HS code vs broker	In customs, trade compliance, and documentation, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
business continuity vs constraint	In supply risk and business continuity, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
S&OP vs owner	In executive s&op decisions, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.